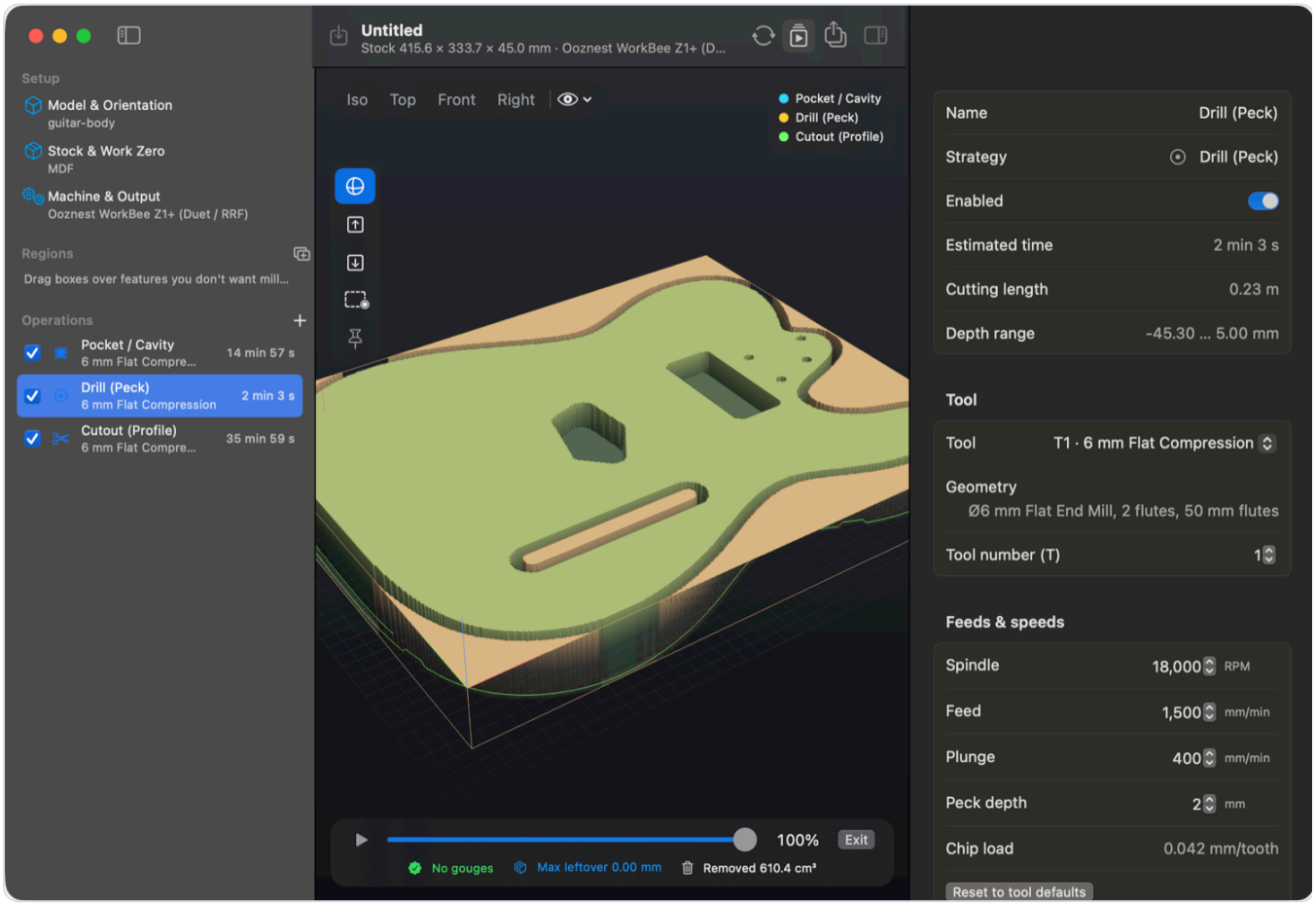
Swarf

User Guide · Mac-native CAM for hobby CNC



Free and open source under the MIT License · github.com/mouldiwarp/swarf

Contents

1 Before you start

2 Installing Swarf

3 The Swarf window

4 Importing and orienting a model

5 Stock, material and work zero

6 Choosing your machine

7 The tool library

8 Operations

9 Cutouts, finishing passes and tabs

10 Peck drilling

11 V-carving

12 Keep-out regions

13 Simulation and checks

14 Exporting G-code

15 Running the job on a WorkBee

16 Troubleshooting

17 Command line

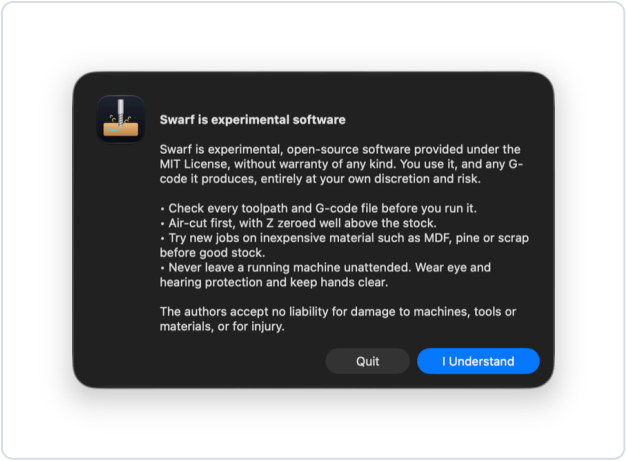
18 Keyboard shortcuts

1 · Before you start

> **Swarf is experimental software. You use it, and any G-code it produces, at your own discretion and risk.**
>
> It is provided under the MIT License without warranty of any kind. The authors accept no liability for damage to machines, tools or materials, or for injury.

Every time Swarf starts, it shows this notice and asks you to click **I Understand**. Clicking **Quit** closes the app. Make these habits part of every job:

- **Check every toolpath** in the 3D view and the simulator before you export.
- **Air-cut first**, with Z zeroed well above the stock, and watch the whole job.
- **Test new jobs on inexpensive material** such as MDF, pine or scrap before you cut good stock.
- **Measure your bits** and correct the tool library. Wrong diameters or flute lengths give wrong toolpaths.
- **Never leave a running machine unattended.** Wear eye and hearing protection and keep your hands clear.



The notice shown at every launch.

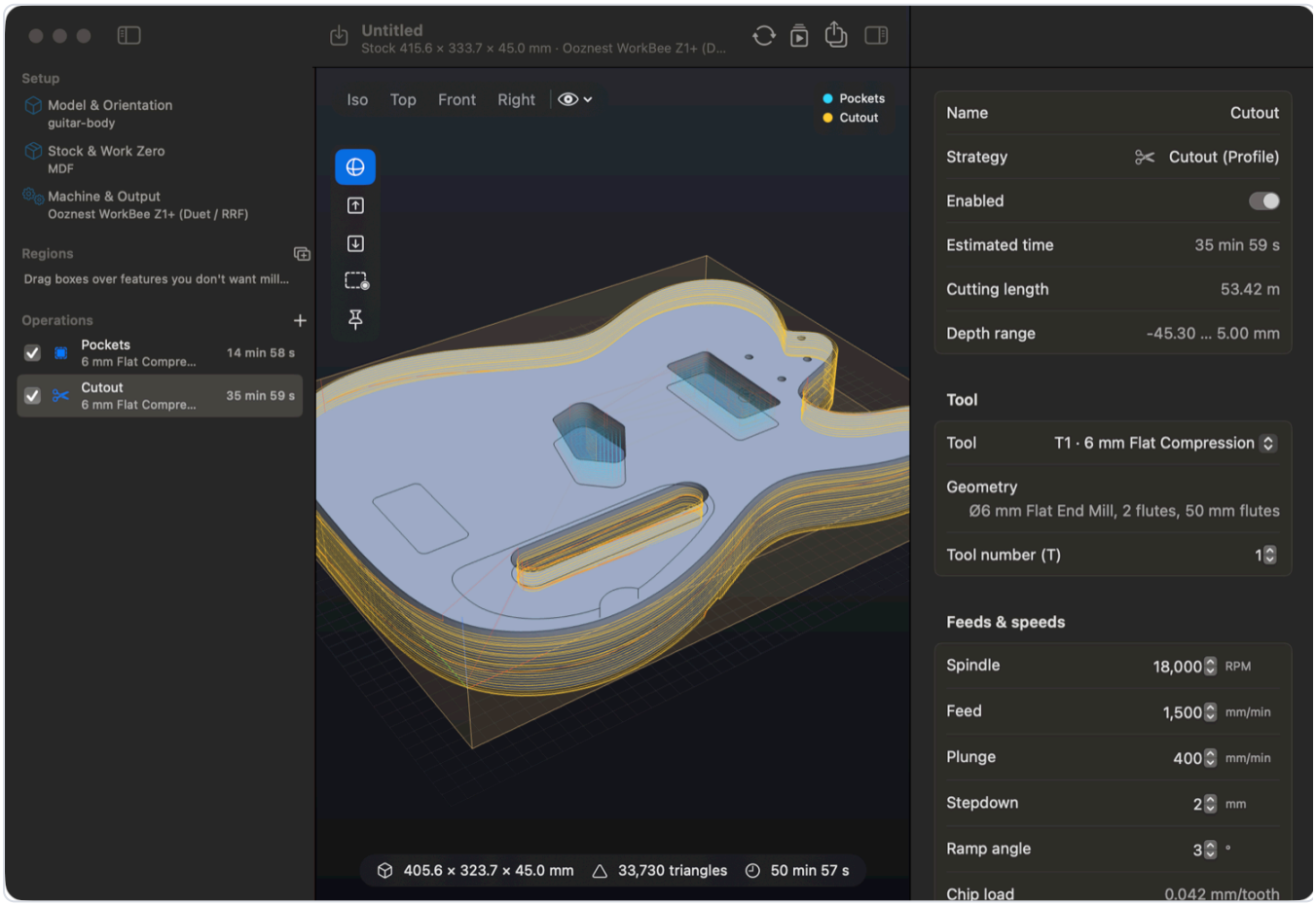
2 · Installing Swarf

Swarf runs on **macOS 15 or later** and builds from source with Xcode 16 or later. Install Xcode (or its command line tools), then in Terminal:

```
git clone https://github.com/mouldiwarp/swarf.git
cd swarf
scripts/build-app.sh          # builds build/Swarf.app
open build/Swarf.app
```

You can copy `build/Swarf.app` to your Applications folder. To update later, run `git pull` and `scripts/build-app.sh` again.

3 · The Swarf window



A guitar body with pocket and cutout toolpaths.

Area	What it does
Sidebar (left)	**Setup** (Model & Orientation, Stock & Work Zero, Machine & Output), **Regions** (keep-out boxes) and the **Operations** list. Tick or untick an operation to turn it on or off. Right-click to duplicate or delete.
Viewport (centre)	The 3D view of the model, the stock and the toolpaths. Use **Iso / Top / Front / Right** for preset views and the eye menu to show or hide layers. The tool strip down the left side switches between orbit, pick face up, pick face down, draw keep-out and place tabs.
Inspector (right)	The settings for whatever is selected in the sidebar.
Toolbar	Import STL, Generate (recalculate the toolpaths), Simulate, Export G-code, and show or hide the inspector.
Status bar	Model size, triangle count, a mesh health warning, and the total estimated run time.

Navigating the 3D view: drag to orbit, scroll or pinch to zoom, and drag with ⇧ or ⌥ held (or right-drag) to pan.

4 · Importing and orienting a model

1. Choose **File ▸ Import STL…** (⇧⌘I), click **Import STL** in the toolbar, or drop an STL on the window. Binary and ASCII STL both work. Swarf never changes your STL file.
2. STL files carry no units. Models smaller than 12 units are assumed to be in inches and scaled ×25.4 automatically. Under **Model & Orientation** you can set the scale yourself or use the **inch → ×25.4** button.
3. Turn the face you want to machine towards the cutter. Use **Lay Flat** (⌥⌘L) to put the largest flat face down, **Pick Face to Point Up** (⌥⌘U) or **Pick Face to Lay on Bed** (⌥⌘D) and click a face, or rotate in 90° steps about X, Y or Z (⌥⌘X / ⌥⌘Y / ⌥⌘Z).
4. Turn on **Highlight undercuts** to see faces a 3-axis machine can't reach from above. If important detail is highlighted, try a different side.

> A **Not watertight** warning in the status bar is usually fine. Swarf works from a height map, so small holes in the mesh don't matter. Check the 3D view for missing faces all the same.

5 · Stock, material and work zero

Select **Stock & Work Zero** in the sidebar.

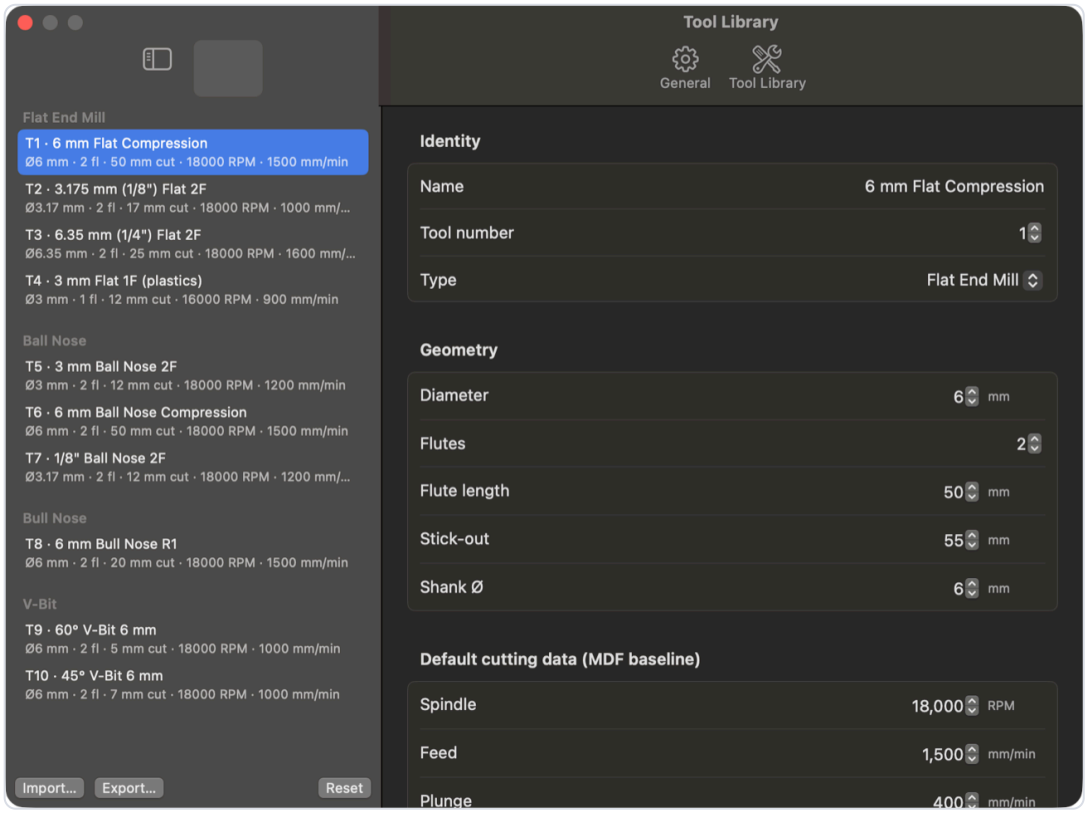
- **Material:** MDF, plywood, softwood, hardwood, acrylic, HDPE, foam or aluminium. The material scales each tool's default speeds and feeds (for example hardwood: feed and plunge ×0.8, stepdown ×0.75). Changing it later leaves existing operations as they are, and a banner offers to rescale them all.
- **Size from model + margins** sizes the stock automatically: set the XY margin and any extra on top or below. Turn it off to enter your real blank: Width (X), Depth (Y) and Thickness (Z).
- **Vertical** places the model at the top, centre or bottom of the stock. **Offset X / Y** shifts it within the blank.
- **Work zero**: pick one of 9 points on the stock, and set **Z zero** to the stock top or the bed. Swarf's default is the **centre of the left edge, top of stock**. Toolpaths start from the work zero, so the preview, the simulation and the G-code all begin at the point you choose.
- **Safe height** is how far above the stock the cutter travels between cuts.
- **Calculation resolution** (draft, normal or fine) trades accuracy for speed. Use draft while you experiment and normal or fine for the real job.

6 · Choosing your machine

Select **Machine & Output** to pick the post-processor. The default is the **Ooznest WorkBee Z1+ (Duet / RRF)**. Profiles are also included for generic RepRapFirmware, GRBL 1.1, Carbide 3D Shapeoko / Nomad, Sienci LongMill / AltMill, X-Carve, Genmitsu, Onefinity, grblHAL / FluidNC, MASSO G3, LinuxCNC, Mach3 / Mach4, UCCNC and Marlin. Each profile knows the machine's work envelope, maximum feeds and spindle range, and Swarf warns you if a job won't fit.

You can set the default machine, material and resolution for new projects in **Swarf ▸ Settings ▸ General**.

7 · The tool library



Swarf ▸ Settings ▸ Tool Library.

Click **Edit Tool Library…** in the Tool section of any operation's settings, or press ⇧⌘T (Window ▸ Tool Library…). It is also under **Swarf ▸ Settings…** (⌘,) ▸ **Tool Library**. Select a tool to edit it, then click **Save** (⌘S) to keep the changes or **Revert** to undo them. Until you save, the tool is marked "(edited)" and nothing else changes; if you pick another tool first, Swarf asks whether to save. **Add Tool** is at the bottom of the list, and Duplicate and Delete are on each tool's right-click menu. **Import…** reads Fusion 360 tool libraries and Swarf JSON files, and **Export…** saves your library. **Reset…** restores the starter set after asking.

- **Type:** flat end mill, ball nose, bull nose (with corner radius), V-bit (with included angle and tip diameter) or drill.
- **Geometry:** diameter, flutes, flute length (the cutting length), stick-out and shank diameter. Swarf warns you when a cut is deeper than the flute length.
- **Default cutting data** (an MDF baseline): spindle speed, feed, plunge, stepdown, stepover and ramp angle. The chip-load readout and warnings help you choose sensible values.
- **Tool number:** the T number written to the G-code.

The starter library includes 6 mm flat and ball-nose compression cutters (50 mm flutes), 1/8", 1/4" and 3 mm cutters, a 6 mm bull nose, and 60° and 45° 6 mm V-bits. New cutouts, pockets and drilling use the 6 mm flat, 3D finishing uses the 6 mm ball, and V-carving uses the 60° V-bit.

> When you edit a tool in the library, open projects that use it pick up the new geometry. Each operation keeps its own feeds and T number, so changing the library never silently changes the feeds of an operation you've already tuned.

8 · Operations

An operation is one machining step with one tool. Click **Full Processing** in the sidebar to let Swarf look at the model and add what it needs: facing if the model sits below the stock top, roughing and finishing for curved tops, pockets for cavities, and a cutout with tabs. Or click **+** to add operations yourself. Operations run in list order. Drag them to reorder.

Swarf recalculates toolpaths automatically when you change a setting or replace the model. To force a fresh calculation of every operation, click **Recalculate All Toolpaths** under the operation list, **Recalculate All** in the toolbar, or press ⌘G.

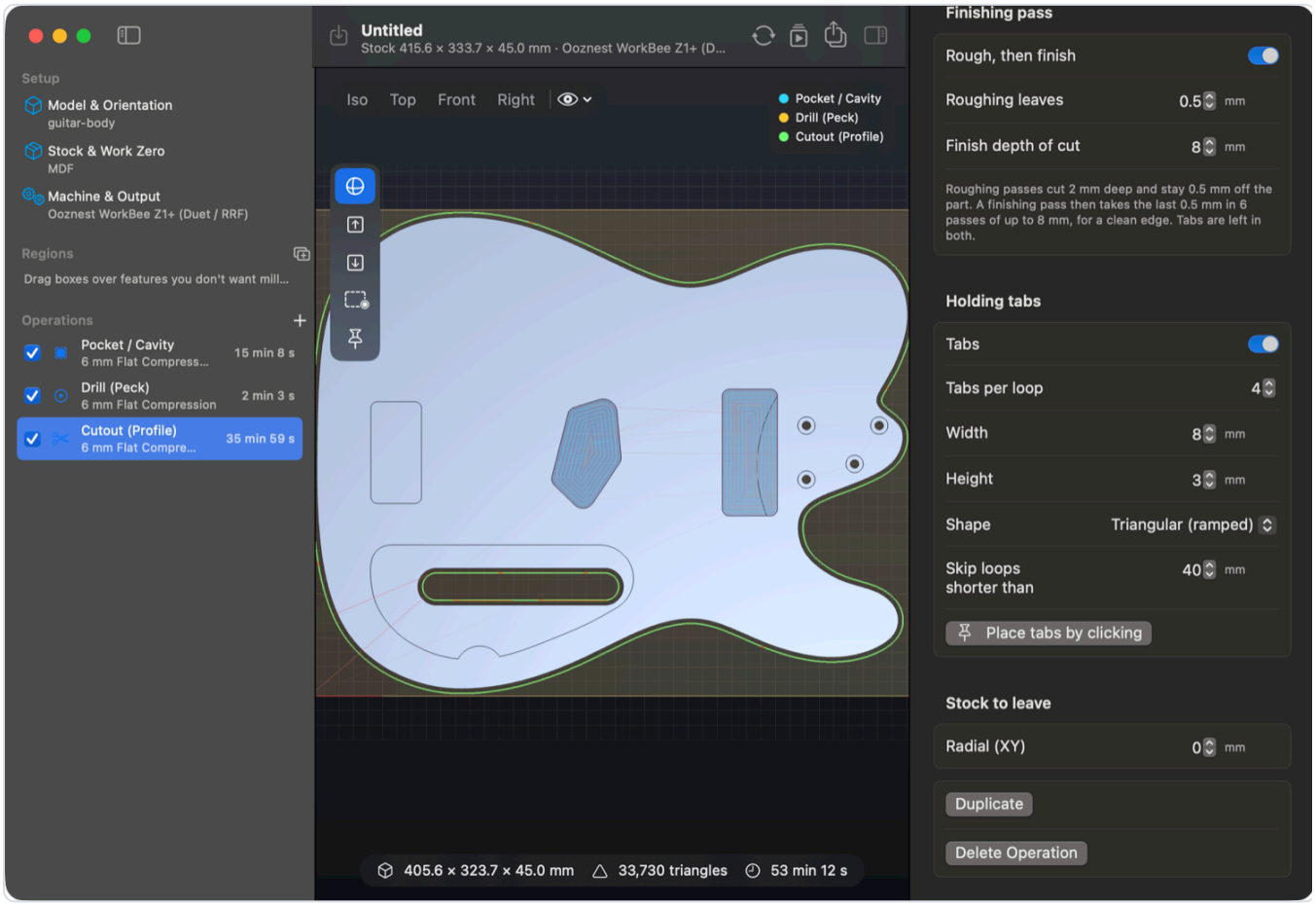
Operation	Use it for
Facing	Flattening the stock top. Set the depth and choose zig-zag or one-way passes.
Pocket / Cavity	Flat-bottomed recesses such as pickup and control cavities. Offset passes with an exact pass on every flat floor.
3D Roughing	Removing bulk material from curved shapes layer by layer, leaving stock for finishing.
3D Finish – Parallel	Smooth surfaces with a ball nose, in raster passes at any angle. Optionally only on slopes below a set angle.
3D Finish – Waterline	Steep walls, using constant-height contours. Optionally only on slopes above a set angle.
V-Carve	Lettering and logos with a V-bit (see chapter 11).
Drill (Peck)	Round holes that match the tool size (see chapter 10).
Cutout (Profile)	Cutting the part free with tabs (see chapter 9).

Settings every operation has

- **Tool** from the library, and its **Tool number (T)**.
- **Feeds & speeds:** spindle RPM, feed, plunge, stepdown (the depth of each pass), stepover (the sideways step, as a percentage of the diameter) and ramp angle. **Reset to tool defaults** reloads them from the library. Library values are for MDF; for other materials Swarf scales them and says so in a banner over the 3D view, with the exact numbers.
- **Depth:** turn on **Limit maximum depth** and enter how far below the stock top this operation may cut. It works for every strategy (pockets, roughing, finishing, cutouts, holes, V-carving, facing), and material below the limit is left. In test-cut mode the shallower of the two limits wins.
- **Area:** boundary (whole stock, model silhouette plus a margin, or inside the model only) and an optional custom bottom height.
- **Stock to leave:** radial (XY) and axial (Z) allowances for a later finishing operation.
- **Direction:** climb or conventional milling.

Changes regenerate the toolpaths automatically. Each operation shows its estimated time, cutting length, depth range and any warnings.

9 · Cutouts, finishing passes and tabs



Cutout settings with roughing passes, a finishing pass and holding tabs.

The cutout follows the outside of the model, offset by the tool radius, and goes through the stock by **Cut below stock** (0.3 mm by default). **Also cut internal holes** cuts through-openings first, while the part is still held at the edges.

Rough, then finish

On by default. The **roughing** passes cut at your normal stepdown but stay **0.5 mm** (**Roughing leaves**) off the part. A **finishing pass** then follows the true outline and removes that last 0.5 mm skin at a much deeper **Finish depth of cut**, 4× the roughing stepdown by default. With a 2 mm stepdown, the finishing pass takes 8 mm per pass. Because it only removes 0.5 mm sideways, the load stays light and the edge comes out clean. If you change the finish depth, a **4×** button puts it back to the default.

Holding tabs

- **Tabs per loop** places tabs automatically and moves them onto straight sections where possible. Or click **Place tabs by clicking** and click on the outline.
- **Width**, **Height** (above the stock bottom) and **Shape** (triangular/ramped or rectangular).
- **Skip loops shorter than** stops small slugs from getting tabs.
- Both the roughing and the finishing passes leave the same tabs. Cut them with a flush-trim saw or chisel and sand them flush.

10 · Peck drilling

Drill (Peck) finds round vertical holes in the model and drills the ones that match the tool, within **Hole size match ±** (0.5 mm by default). Holes of other sizes are listed in a warning. Larger through holes are cut by the cutout, and larger blind holes need a pocket.

- **Peck depth** (the operation's stepdown, half the tool diameter by default) is how far each peck goes, at the plunge rate.
- **Full retract** backs out to 1 mm above the stock after every peck to clear chips, then drops quickly back to 0.5 mm above the last depth. Use it for deep holes.
- **Chip break** just lifts a little (**Chip-break lift**) to snap the chip. It's faster for shallow holes.
- Blind holes stop at their floor. Through holes go below the stock by **Through holes: below stock**. A pointed drill goes deeper still, so its full diameter comes out of the bottom face.
- The output is plain G0/G1 moves, so it runs on any firmware.

> Drill **before** the cutout, so the part is still held while it's drilled.

11 · V-carving

V-Carve engraves with a V-bit. The bit follows the centre line of each shape and goes deeper where the shape is wider, so edges and corners stay sharp. **Engrave** chooses what is carved:

- **Recesses**: areas sunk into the model's top face, such as text in a plaque.
- **Silhouette**: the model's whole outline, such as an STL of extruded lettering, carved into the stock top.

Limit depth (flat bottom) caps the depth for wide shapes. Stepdown splits deep carves into several passes. Use keep-out or machine-only regions to limit what gets engraved. A 60° bit carves deeper and narrower than a 90° bit, and a 45° bit deeper still. Set the bit's tip diameter in the library if it isn't sharp.

12 · Keep-out regions

Keep-out boxes protect features you don't want milled, or cover clamps.

1. Click the draw-keep-out tool in the viewport strip (or the button next to **Regions**, ⌥⌘K) and drag a box in the 3D view.
2. Click a box to select it. It turns orange. Drag it to move it, nudge it with the arrow keys (1 mm; ⇧ 10 mm; ⌥ 0.1 mm), or press ⌫ to delete it. Click empty space to deselect.
3. In the inspector, set exact coordinates, switch the type to **Machine only within** (which limits operations to the inside of the box), or turn on **Allow cutting down to a height** to protect only what's below a set Z.

The cutter stays a full radius away from keep-outs in every operation except cutouts. The simulator reports any keep-out violations.

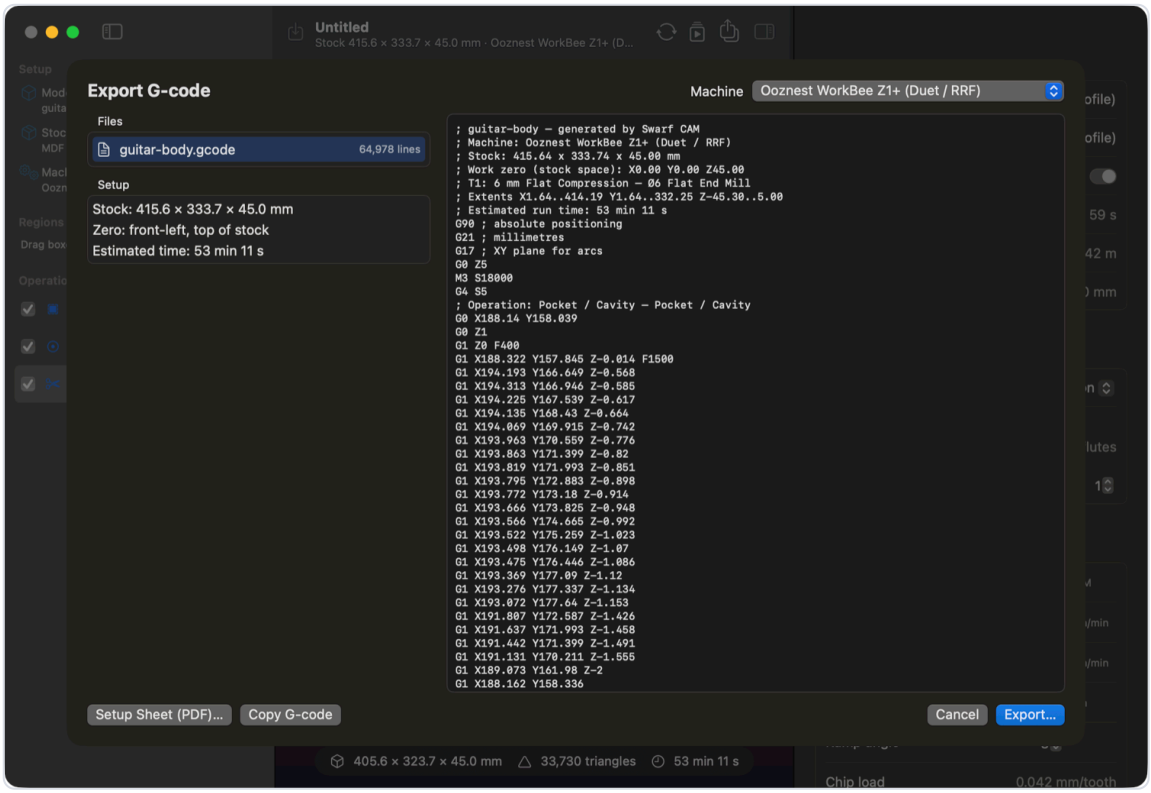
13 · Simulation and checks

Click **Simulate** (⌘R) to remove material from a virtual block of stock. Use the scrubber or play button to watch the job. Below the scrubber you'll see:

- **Gouges**: places cut deeper than the model, shown in red. A good job says **No gouges**.
- **Max leftover**: material left behind, shown as a blue heat map. Expect some in inside corners smaller than the tool.
- **Removed** volume and any **keep-out violations**.

Click **Exit** to return to the toolpath view. Warnings such as feeds out of range, cuts deeper than the flute length, a job outside the machine envelope, or cuts below the stock bottom appear on each operation in the inspector.

14 · Exporting G-code



The export sheet, with a preview of the WorkBee G-code.

1. Click **Export G-code** (⌘E). Check the machine, the list of files, the stock size, the zero point and the run time.
2. Read the preview. The header lists the stock, the work zero, each tool and the run time.
3. Type a name in **File name** if you don't want the model's name. The file list shows the result, and the project remembers the name for next time. Click **Export…** and choose a folder. **Setup Sheet (PDF)…** saves a printable sheet with the stock, the zero point, a top view and the tool list. **Copy G-code** puts the program on the clipboard. Tick **Show G-code** to see the first 400 lines of the selected file; it is off by default, and Swarf remembers your choice.

For the WorkBee, Swarf writes **one file per tool**, numbered in the order they run. Other machines get a single file with tool-change commands where the controller supports them.

15 · Running the job on a WorkBee

1. Fix the stock down, keeping clamps outside the toolpaths (or covered by keep-outs).
2. Fit the first tool. Jog to the **work zero shown in the setup sheet** (by default the centre of the stock's left edge) and set X and Y zero.
3. Probe or touch off Z on the **top of the stock**.
4. Upload the first file in the Duet web interface. For the first run, raise Z zero 10–20 mm and air-cut the start of the job.
5. Run the file. Stay at the machine with your hand near the emergency stop.

6. For each further file: change the bit, re-probe Z (keep X and Y), and run it.

16 · Troubleshooting

Problem	What to try
"Operation produced no toolpath" or "Nothing to clear"	The tool may be too big for the feature, or the boundary excludes it. Try a smaller tool, or change the Area boundary.
Drilling skips holes	The holes don't match the tool diameter. Raise **Hole size match ±**, choose a matching tool, or use a pocket.
"Cut depth exceeds the tool's flute length"	The job is deeper than the bit can cut. Use a longer bit, or check the flute length in the tool library.
"Cuts below the stock bottom"	Check the stock thickness and model placement. For V-carving, set a depth limit or use a wider-angle bit.
Chip-load warnings	Low chip load rubs and burns, so raise the feed or lower the RPM. High chip load stresses the bit, so do the opposite.
Generating is slow	Use draft resolution while setting up and switch to normal or fine for the final job.
Model too small or large	It was probably modelled in inches or metres. Set the scale under Model & Orientation.

17 · Command line

`swarf-cli` runs the same engine without the app:

```
swift build -c release
.build/release/swarf-cli model.stl --out ./gcode --simulate --png preview.png
.build/release/swarf-cli model.stl --ops pocket,drill,cutout --material plywood
.build/release/swarf-cli --list-machines
```

Options: `--machine`, `--material`, `--quality draft|normal|fine`, `--lay-flat`, `--rotate x:90`, `--ops` (facing, pocket, roughing, parallelFinish, waterlineFinish, vcarve, drill, cutout), `--keepout x0,y0,x1,y1`, `--vcarve-source recesses|silhouette`, `--vcarve-depth`.

18 · Keyboard shortcuts

Action	Shortcut	Action	Shortcut
Import STL	⇧⌘I	Lay flat	⌥⌘L
Recalculate all toolpaths	⌘G	Pick face to point up	⌥⌘U
Simulate	⌘R	Pick face to lay on bed	⌥⌘D
Export G-code	⌘E	Rotate 90° about X / Y / Z	⌥⌘X / ⌥⌘Y / ⌥⌘Z
Settings / tool library	⌘,	Draw keep-out	⌥⌘K
Undo / Redo	⌘Z / ⇧⌘Z	Move / delete selected keep-out	Arrows / ⌫

Swarf is free software under the MIT License, provided "as is", without warranty of any kind. Source, issues and contributions: github.com/mouldiwarp/swarf.